

ENDPOINT MANAGEMENT WITH MICROSOFT INTUNE

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ISEC 2078 Assignment #4

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

This report outlines a plan to address critical security vulnerabilities and operational inefficiencies within the company's current device management strategy. The existing ad-hoc process, which relies on manual spreadsheet tracking, lacks automation, centralized security policies, and remote management capabilities. This was highlighted by a recent data breach that originated from a lost, unmanaged corporate laptop. The proposed solution is a complete adoption of the Microsoft Intune Suite, a cloud-based Unified Endpoint Management (UEM) platform. By implementing Intune, the organization can replace its outdated manual system with a centralized, automated, and secure framework. This will enable zero-touch/automated device deployment for new hires, enforce crucial security policies such as mandatory data encryption, and provide essential remote management capabilities, including the ability to locate and remotely wipe lost or stolen devices. This strategic shift aligns with a modern Zero Trust security model, ensuring a scalable and secure foundation for managing all organizational endpoints, including laptops, tablets, and smartphones.

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MDM RESEARCH

IDENTIFYING GAPS

The recent data breach was a direct result of fundamental weaknesses in the current device management process. The practice of manually installing an operating system and applications, then recording the device's model and MAC address in a spreadsheet, is outdated and insecure. This system fails in two critical areas. First, it lacks automation, creating a significant workload for IT staff and increasing the potential for human error. Second, it provides no method for ongoing security policy enforcement or remote intervention. When the laptop was reported lost, the IT department had no technical means to locate, lock, or remotely erase its data. This lack of control left the organization vulnerable and directly led to the breach.

To correct these issues, the organization must adopt a comprehensive security strategy known as Unified Endpoint Management (UEM). UEM platforms provide a single, integrated console to manage a diverse ecosystem of devices, including Windows, macOS, iOS, and Android endpoints, whether they are corporate-owned or personal devices used for work (BYOD).

PROPOSED PLATFORM

The recommended solution is the Microsoft Intune Suite, a cloud-based UEM service that is a core part of Microsoft's enterprise management ecosystem. Intune integrates with Microsoft Entra ID for identity management and Microsoft Defender for Endpoint for threat protection, creating a unified security framework.

The Intune Suite is an add-on to the standard Intune license that provides advanced capabilities crucial for a healthcare environment. These features include:

- **Endpoint Privilege Management (EPM):** Allows IT to grant users temporary, administrative rights for specific tasks, enforcing a least-privilege security model.
- **Remote Help:** A secure, cloud-based tool that enables IT to provide remote assistance to users on any managed device, improving support efficiency.

- **Advanced Analytics:** Provides data-driven insights into device health and user experience, allowing IT to proactively identify and resolve issues.

By using the Intune Suite, the organization can consolidate multiple management functions into a single platform, which simplifies administration and establishes a security posture based on Zero Trust concepts.

ALIGNING CAPABILITIES

The Microsoft Intune Suite meets all technical and security requirements for this project. This section maps those requirements to the platform's specific features.

AUTOMATED ENROLLMENT

The primary requirement is to automate the device deployment process. Microsoft Intune accomplishes this with Windows Autopilot, a mechanism that enables “zero-touch” deployment for new Windows devices. Instead of IT manually setting up each machine, a device's unique hardware ID can be registered in Intune beforehand. The device can then be shipped directly to the user, who simply connects it to the internet and signs in with their work credentials, which is ideal for 100% remote workers. Autopilot then automatically applies all company configurations, security policies, and applications without further IT intervention.

CENTRALIZED MANAGEMENT

Intune is managed through a web-based admin center, providing IT with the ability to enforce security policies remotely. These policies include:

- **Device Configuration Policies:** Enforce settings like full-disk encryption (BitLocker for Windows), password complexity, and firewalls.
- **Device Compliance Policies:** Define a baseline for a “healthy” device, checking for an up-to-date OS and active antivirus protection. Devices that fail to meet these standards are marked as non-compliant and can be blocked from accessing corporate resources.

LOCATION AND GEOFENCING

Intune provides two key capabilities for location-based control.

- **Geolocation:** For corporate-owned devices, the “Locate device” remote action can retrieve a device's current geographical coordinates and display them on a map. This feature is supported on Windows, supervised iOS/iPadOS devices, and corporate-owned Android devices. To protect privacy, location data is encrypted, collected only when the action is triggered, and automatically deleted after 24 hours.
- **Geofencing:** Intune implements geofencing through integration with Microsoft Entra Conditional Access. Instead of drawing a simple map boundary, administrators can define “Named Locations” based on trusted IP address ranges (like the corporate office) or entire countries. A Conditional Access policy can then be created to control access to sensitive data. For example, a policy could block access to patient records unless the user is connecting from a trusted network location and using a compliant device. This identity-driven approach is more secure and flexible than traditional geofencing.

MULTI-PLATFORM SUPPORT

Intune supports Windows, macOS, iOS, and Android, offering different management levels for corporate and personal devices.

- **Mobile Device Management (MDM):** This is for corporate-owned devices and provides full control, allowing IT to enforce policies, deploy apps, and perform remote wipes.
- **Mobile Application Management (MAM):** This is for personally owned devices (BYOD). MAM, also known as App Protection Policies, creates a secure container for corporate apps like Outlook and Teams. IT can enforce security within these apps, such as requiring a PIN or preventing data from being copied to personal apps, without managing the user's personal device. This protects corporate data while respecting user privacy.

Table 1: Cross-Platform Feature Availability.

	Windows 11	Windows 10	macOS	iOS	iPadOS	Android
Automated Enrollment	✓ *	✓ *	✓ **	✓ **	✓ **	✓ ***
Configuration Policies	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Compliance Policies	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Remote Wipe	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Geolocation	✓	✓	✓	✓ ****	✓ ****	✓
App Protection	✓	✓	N/A	✓	✓	✓

* Requires Windows Autopilot
 ** Requires Apple Business Manager
 *** Requires Android Zero-Touch
 **** Device must be configured as “Supervised”

REPORTING AND ALARMS

Intune provides a comprehensive reporting framework with operational, organizational, historical, and specialist reports that give insight into device compliance, health, and trends. For remote alarms, the “Play lost device sound” action can be used on corporate Android and supervised iOS devices to help locate them. Additionally, administrators can send custom text notifications to the Company Portal app on any managed device.

ACCESS AND INTEGRATION

Intune is built on Microsoft Entra ID, the cloud-based successor of Active Directory (AD). It supports Microsoft Entra hybrid joined devices, which allows organizations to use on-premises AD while transitioning to cloud management. For access control, Intune uses a Role-Based Access Control (RBAC) model, allowing for the creation of custom admin roles with specific permissions, such as a “Help Desk Operator” who can perform remote actions but cannot change security policies. This aligns with the security principle of least privilege.

REQUIRED RESOURCES

LICENSING

Microsoft Intune Plan 1 is included in many Microsoft 365 licenses. The recommended Intune Suite is an add-on that requires an additional license.

TECHNICAL TRAINING

IT staff will need training on the platform. Microsoft offers extensive free training resources through its Microsoft Learn platform.

SERVER HARDWARE

As a cloud-native solution, Intune eliminates the need for on-premises server hardware, which reduces costs and maintenance overhead.

USER TRAINING

A communication plan and training will be needed to familiarize users with the Company Portal app, which they will use for self-service tasks like installing approved software.

IMPLEMENTATION

This section provides step-by-step procedures for an entry-level IT professional to perform key device management tasks using Microsoft Intune.

DEVICE ENROLLMENT

WINDOWS DEVICES – AUTOPILOT

This procedure provisions a new corporate Windows laptop using a zero-touch process.

ACQUIRE HARDWARE HASH

For new devices, arrange for the vendor to upload the device's unique hardware hash directly to your Intune tenant. For existing devices, you can manually collect the hash using a PowerShell script during the initial Windows setup.

VERIFY DEVICE REGISTRATION

In the Microsoft Intune admin center, navigate to **Devices > Windows > Windows enrollment > Devices** to confirm the new device appears in the Windows Autopilot list.

CREATE AND ASSIGN DEPLOYMENT PROFILE

Navigate to **Deployment Profiles** and create a new profile. Configure the **Deployment mode** to **User-Driven** and set the **User account type** to **Standard** to enforce least privilege. Assign this profile to a dynamic device group that contains all Autopilot devices.

CONFIGURE ENROLLMENT STATUS PAGE (ESP)

Create and assign an ESP profile. This page displays during setup and can be configured to block device use until all critical security policies and applications are installed, ensuring the device is secure before use.

END-USER EXPERIENCE

The employee unboxes the new device, connects to the internet, and signs in with their work credentials. The ESP will show the configuration progress, and once complete, the user will have a fully provisioned and secure desktop.

APPLE DEVICES (IOS/IPADOS AND MACOS)

Apple offers two primary methods for corporate enrollment: an automated, zero-touch process via Apple Business Manager (ABM) for new devices, and a more manual process using Apple Configurator for existing devices.

AUTOMATED ENROLLMENT – APPLE BUSINESS MANAGER

ABM is Apple's web portal for managing device deployments and is the equivalent of Windows Autopilot for the Apple ecosystem. It provides a zero-touch experience for new devices purchased from Apple or authorized resellers. The process involves linking Intune and ABM, assigning devices to the Intune MDM server within the ABM portal, and then creating and assigning an enrollment profile in Intune. The end-user experience is seamless; the user unboxes the device, connects it to the internet, and the device automatically enrolls and configures itself based on the assigned Intune profile.

MANUAL ENROLLMENT – APPLE CONFIGURATOR

Apple Configurator is a macOS application for hands-on device configuration, which is ideal for enrolling existing devices not purchased through ABM.

ADDING EXISTING DEVICES TO ABM

For existing devices, Apple Configurator can add them to your ABM account. This involves connecting the device to a Mac running the app. This process registers the device's serial number in ABM, allowing it to then use the automated enrollment workflow described above. This is the preferred method for existing corporate devices, as it enables full supervision and a streamlined enrollment experience.

DIRECT ENROLLMENT

This method enrolls a device directly into Intune without ABM, which is useful for shared or kiosk-style devices without an assigned user. An IT professional creates an enrollment profile in Intune, exports it as a *.mobileconfig* file, and then uses Apple Configurator on a Mac to apply this file to each device via a USB connection. This manual process must be repeated for every device being enrolled.

DEVICE TRACKING

This procedure finds the last known location of a lost corporate-owned device.

1. **Prerequisites:** Ensure Location Services are enabled on the device through a device configuration profile in Intune. The device must be online to report its current location.
2. Log in to the Microsoft Intune admin center.
3. Navigate to **Devices > All devices**.
4. Search for and select the target device to open its overview page.
5. In the toolbar, select the Locate device remote action. You may need to click the ellipsis (...) to find it.
6. Confirm the action. After a few moments, the device's location will appear on a map. The location data is stored for 24 hours before being automatically deleted.

REMOTE DISABLEMENT

This procedure is for remotely erasing all data from a lost or stolen corporate device to prevent a data breach. For this scenario, the Wipe action is appropriate, as it performs a factory reset. The Retire action is less destructive and is used for BYOD or offboarding scenarios where only corporate data is removed.

1. Navigate to the target device's overview page in the Intune admin center.
2. Select the Wipe remote action from the toolbar.
3. In the confirmation pane, enable the option "Wipe device, and continue to wipe even if device loses power." This ensures the data erasure process cannot be easily interrupted.
4. Confirm the action. The next time the device connects to the internet, it will receive the command and begin the factory reset process, securely erasing all data.

DEVICE UNENROLLMENT

This procedure is for properly removing a device from management when an employee leaves the organization.

1. Navigate to the target device's overview page in the Intune admin center.
2. Select the Retire remote action. This unenrolls the device and removes all company-managed data and applications while leaving personal data intact.
3. Perform administrative cleanup:
 - **Deregister from Autopilot:** In the Windows Autopilot devices section, find and delete the device to remove it from the Autopilot service.
 - **Delete from Microsoft Entra ID:** In the Microsoft Entra admin center, find and delete the device object to remove it from the organization's identity system.

DISASTER RECOVERY

For a cloud service like Intune, disaster recovery focuses on recovering from administrative errors, such as the accidental deletion of a critical policy, rather than hardware failure. The recommended method for backing up Intune configurations is using PowerShell and the Microsoft Graph API.

BACKUP PROCEDURE (AUTOMATED)

1. Create a PowerShell script that connects to the Microsoft Graph API.
2. Use Get-* cmdlets to retrieve all critical configuration objects (e.g., compliance policies, configuration profiles, app protection policies).
3. Export each object as a JSON file and save it to a secure, version-controlled location like a private GitHub repository.
4. Run this script as a scheduled task (e.g., daily) to maintain current backups.

RESTORE PROCEDURE (MANUAL)

1. In the event of a disaster, an administrator would run a corresponding restore script.
2. This script would read the configuration data from the saved JSON files.
3. It would then use New-* or Add-* cmdlets to recreate the policies and profiles in Intune from the backup files.
4. This procedure should be documented and tested regularly to ensure its effectiveness.

VULNERABILITIES AND MITIGATION

Adopting Microsoft Intune improves endpoint security, but the management platform itself becomes a target. This section analyzes potential vulnerabilities and outlines mitigation strategies.

PRIVILEGED ACCOUNT COMPROMISE

VULNERABILITY

An attacker gains control of an account with high-level administrative privileges in Intune, such as an “Intune Administrator” or “Global Administrator.”

THREAT

With this access, an attacker could deploy ransomware to all devices, disable security policies like encryption, or issue a wipe command to all corporate devices, causing catastrophic data loss and operational disruption

MITIGATION

ENFORCE LEAST PRIVILEGE

Use Intune's Role-Based Access Control (RBAC) to assign administrators only the permissions they need for their job. For example, helpdesk staff should not have permissions to create or modify security policies. Use Endpoint Privilege Management (EPM) to allow standard users to run specific IT-approved tasks with elevated rights, removing the need for them to be local administrators.

REQUIRE PHISHING-RESISTANT MFA

Use a Conditional Access policy to mandate phishing-resistant multi-factor authentication (MFA), such as FIDO2 security keys, for all administrative roles.

IMPLEMENT PRIVILEGED IDENTITY MANAGEMENT

Use Microsoft Entra PIM to provide just-in-time (JIT) access. This requires admins to “check out” their privileged roles for a limited time, and all actions are logged.

MISCONFIGURED POLICIES

VULNERABILITY

A Conditional Access policy is misconfigured, for example, by being left in “Report-only” mode or by having an overly broad exclusion rule.

THREAT

A non-compliant, unencrypted device could be used to access sensitive patient data because the policy intended to block it is not active. This completely undermines the security controls.

MITIGATION

USE REPORT-ONLY MODE FOR TESTING

Before enabling any new or modified Conditional Access policy, deploy it in **“Report-only” mode**. This allows you to see the policy's potential impact in the sign-in logs without actually blocking users, preventing accidental lockouts.

ADOPT A PHASED ROLLOUT

Always test new policies with a small pilot group (e.g., the IT department) before deploying them to the entire organization.

MAINTAIN EXCLUDED ACCOUNTS

Create two or three emergency access accounts that are explicitly excluded from all Conditional Access policies. These accounts ensure you can regain access to the tenant if a misconfiguration locks out all other administrators.

BYOD DATA LEAKAGE

VULNERABILITY

A user on a personally owned (BYOD) phone accesses corporate data in a managed application (e.g., Outlook) and moves it to an unmanaged personal application (e.g., a personal notes app or email).

THREAT

This action constitutes data exfiltration. Sensitive patient information could be leaked from corporate control, leading to a data breach and regulatory violations.

MITIGATION

ENFORCE APP PROTECTION POLICIES

This is the core strategy for BYOD security. MAM policies create a secure container around corporate applications. These policies can be configured to prevent data from being copied from a managed app and pasted into an unmanaged app.

BLOCK UNMANAGED APPS

Use a Conditional Access policy that requires an “app protection policy” to access corporate data. This blocks native mail clients and other unmanaged apps, forcing users to access data through the secure, managed Outlook app.

RESTRICT DATA MOVEMENT

Configure the MAM policy to prevent saving corporate data to personal storage locations and to restrict cut, copy, and paste actions between managed and unmanaged applications.

CONCLUSION

The current manual approach to device management is inadequate and exposes the organization to significant risk. The Microsoft Intune Suite provides a comprehensive, cloud-based solution that directly addresses these shortcomings. It enables automation through Windows Autopilot, enforces robust security through centralized policies, and provides critical remote management capabilities. By integrating with the broader Microsoft security ecosystem and aligning with a Zero Trust framework, Intune offers a scalable and resilient platform to secure all endpoints. Adopting this solution is an essential step to protect patient data, ensure regulatory compliance, and modernize the organization's security posture.

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